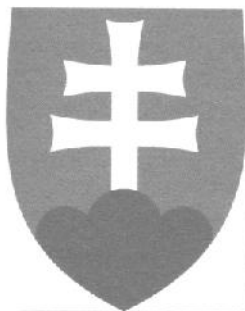


30 SLOVAKIA – MY HOMELAND



Patriotism is your conviction that this country is superior to all other countries because you were born in it.

George Bernard Shaw

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **national symbols and other facts:** flag (three horizontal stripes: white, blue and red, state emblem on the left side – a silver double-cross on the central hill of three hills), coat of arms, seal, anthem, constitution, currency (Euro), the head of state (president), official language (Slovak)
- **location of Slovakia:** Central Europe, heart of Europe, borders with the Czech Republic, the Ukraine, Hungary, Poland and Austria; natural borders (the Moravia, the Danube, the Carpathians, the High Tatras)
- **history:** Great Moravian Empire (830–896), arrival of the Byzantine brothers Constantine and Methodius (863), Austrian-Hungarian Monarchy (10th century–1918), codification of the Slovak language by L. Štúr (1843), the Czechoslovak Republic (1918), World War I/II., Slovak National Uprising (1944), Prague Spring, Velvet Revolution (fall of communism, restoration of democracy in 1989), establishment of the Slovak Republic (1993), accession of Slovakia to the European Union (2004)
- **towns and places to visit:**
 - capital (seat of government, parliament), large towns (galleries, museums, exhibitions, theatres, cinemas, cultural events, universities), small towns, villages, countryside, architecture, *skanzen* (open-air museum)
 - the High Tatras, the Low Tatras, the Little Fatras, the Great Fatras, Slovak Paradise (spectacular scenery, mountains, lowlands, highlands, valleys, fairy tale castles, caves, spa resorts, ski resorts, chateaux)
- **Slovak traditions and habits:** folklore, festivals, national costumes, Slovak cuisine, national dish, special Easter traditions with willow whips and pouring water, *Fašiangy* (Carnival, Pentecost)
- **stereotype of Slovak people:** patriotic, hospitable, amicable, family-oriented, generous, helpful, skilful, bright, modest, loud, money conscious, property protective, overcaring parents
- **membership of the European Union:** market economy, different lifestyle, job opportunities, new currency, multiculturalism, brain-drain, EU funded projects, regional development, education, trade, commerce, agriculture, industry (machinery, breweries, distilleries, ironworks, textile, chemical, mining), power plants
- **souvenirs:** dolls dressed in folk costumes, little figures and other items made from corn husks, ceramics (jars, vases), crystal, *čipka* (lace), embroidery, *valaška* (decorated folk hatchet), Slovak flag
- **system of government:** legislative branch (Parliament – 150 members), executive branch (Government headed by the Prime Minister, the President – Commander in Chief), judicial branch (Constitutional Court, Supreme Court, regional and district courts)

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Do you think Slovakia is an attractive tourist destination?
2. Which towns in Slovakia are definitely worth seeing?
3. Which places would you recommend to nature lovers to see?
4. Which national meals/drinks would you offer foreigners?
5. Which famous Slovak personalities do you think are good role models?
6. What is said about the Slovaks?
7. What needs to be done to make Slovakia more attractive for foreign tourists?
8. What are Slovakia's national symbols?
9. How would you translate the first verse of the Slovak national anthem into English?
10. Are you proud to be Slovak? Why?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

THE SLOVAK REPUBLIC AND ITS LOCATION

The Slovak Republic is an independent state situated in Central Europe that came into existence on January 1, 1993 after separating from the Czech Republic. To the west it **borders** by the Czech Republic, to the north by Poland, to the east by the Ukraine and to the south by Hungary and Austria. The borders are mostly natural, made by rivers (the Moravia, the Danube) and mountains (**the Carpathians**, the High Tatras). Slovakia is often called the "country in the heart of Europe". The geographical centre of Europe is situated on the Krahule hill not far from the **historic** town of Kremnica. It is a mostly mountainous country, **rich in** fauna and flora. It has much to offer to tourists who come here to see some of the most **spectacular scenery** in Europe, old towns and cities, **fairy tale castles**, **caves** and **spa resorts**.

1. Which countries is Slovakia bordered by?
2. Why is Slovakia called "the country in the heart of Europe"?

CRUCIAL HISTORIC EVENTS

Slovakia is attractive for foreign visitors also because of its history. Visitors can learn about the history of the *Great Moravian Empire* or the *Austrian-Hungarian Monarchy*. They also like to learn about its **recent** history, especially the *Slovak National Uprising* or the *Czechoslovak Socialist Republic*. They are also interested in the events of the *Prague Spring* or the so called *Velvet Revolution* of November 1989. Nowadays, they visit an independent country which is a member of the European Union. In May 2004, Slovakia became a member of the European Union together with other nine countries. The Slovak language became one of the **official** languages of the European Union. This **membership** has influenced the political and economic life of the country **considerably**. Slovak companies and institutions **participate in** various EU **funded** projects **concerning** the environment, regional development, education, **trade** and other **spheres**. Slovak students get involved in exchange programmes and study abroad. **Despite the fact** that several EU countries have **imposed** job **entry restrictions** on Slovaks, a lot of doctors, programmers, engineers, **researchers** and others have decided to work abroad.

3. Which historic events mentioned in the text above are remarkable for foreign visitors?
4. What opportunities emerged for Slovaks when their country joined the EU?

NATURAL SCENERY

There are many interesting places to visit in Slovakia. There are several national parks and **protected regions** (e.g. *the High Tatras*, *the Low Tatras*, *the Little Fatras*, *the Great Fatras*, *Slovak Paradise* and others). **The High Tatras** are situated in the north of Slovakia and create a natural border between Slovakia and Poland. The highest **peak**, *Gerlachovský štít* (2 655 m), is situated in the middle of the whole **massif** and it is **visible from far and wide**. The eastern part of the High Tatras is dominated by the *Lomnický štít* peak (2 632 m) and the western part by the *Kriváň* peak (2 494 m). With its **natural beauties**, this area attracts many tourists **throughout** the year. The High Tatras are famous for their many **valleys** with mountain lakes which are largely the results of **glacial** activity. The most frequently visited lake is *Štrbské pleso* situated **at a height of** 1 355 metres. It **owes its popularity** not only to wonderful **views** of the **surrounding** mountain peaks but also to an excellent climate. For tourists interested in older architecture there is *Starý Smokovec*, one of the oldest **settlements** in the High Tatras. *The High Tatras National Park* is Slovakia's largest. *Slovak Paradise* is a romantic and **picturesque** region located in the northeast. There are numerous rock windows, caves and **roaring waterfalls** as well as **vast plains** with fascinating views of the area. *Dobšinská Ice Cave*, located in the western part of this valley, is the oldest ice cave in Europe. It is one of the most attractive places for tourists visiting Slovak Paradise.

5. What national parks are there in Slovakia?
6. In the text above, which places in the High Tatras are considered to be the most interesting ones?

OTHER INTERESTING PLACES AND TOWNS

Other places attractive for tourists include *Spiš Castle*, the largest **medieval** castle in Central Europe and *Vlkolínec*, a mountain village with typical folklore architecture. Both of them have been included in the *UNESCO World Cultural Heritage List* among other protected sites, such as *Banská Štiavnica*, *Bardejov*, *Ochtinská aragonitová jaskyňa* (Ochtinská Aragonit Cave), *Gombasecká jaskyňa* (Gombasecká Cave), etc. The capital of Slovakia, *Bratislava*, is the political, cultural and industrial centre of the country. The larger towns of Slovakia include *Košice*, *Prešov*, *Nitra*, *Žilina*, *Banská Bystrica*, *Trnava*, and *Martin*. The smaller towns and villages most frequently visited by tourists because of their rich cultural history and beautiful architecture include *Banská Štiavnica* (famous for mining), *Kremnica*, *Bardejov*, *Levoča* (with the largest wooden **altar** in the world made by Master Paul in the early 16th century), *Kežmarok* and *Ždiar*. Many smaller Slovak towns, e.g. *Bojnice*, *Zvolen*, *Trenčín*, *Oravský Podzámok*, *Spišská Nová Ves*, *Krásna Hôrka* and *Antol* are famous for their castles and **chateaux**.

7. Which places are included in the UNESCO World Cultural Heritage List?
8. What do Slovak cities and towns mentioned in the text above offer visiting tourists?

STEREOTYPING SLOVAKS (FEATURES, HABITS, NATIONAL ICONS)

The Slovaks are famous for being patriots, which means they have a positive **attitude** to their country. They are **proud of** their folklore tradition which is well-developed. In every region, there exist many folklore groups. Various traditions connected to **Easter** or Christmas are still kept, especially in the villages. There are many typical Slovak restaurants serving traditional Slovak **cuisine**. The most typical food is *bryndzové halušky* (**gnocchi** with sheep cheese) and typical alcoholic drinks include *borovička* (**juniper gin**), *slivovica* (plum brandy) and beer. There are also non-alcoholic drinks as well, for example *žinčica* (a kind of sour milk).

Typical souvenirs can be bought in specialised shops in every region in Slovakia. The most popular souvenirs are dolls dressed in folk costumes, little figures and other items made from **corn husks**, **ceramics** (**jars**, vases, **pitchers**), crystal glass, **laced** and **embroidered** scarves and **tablecloths**, *valaška* (a decorated folk **hatchet**) and *fujara* (a folk instrument).

9. What are the Slovaks like according to the text above? Do you agree?
10. Which are the most popular Slovak souvenirs?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

altar [ˈɔ:lta(r)] – oltár
attitude – postoj
because of – kvôli
to border – hraničiť
cave [keɪv] – jaskyňa
ceramics [səˈræmɪks] – keramika
chateaux [ʃætu] – kaštieľ
to concern – týkať sa
considerably – značne
corn husk [kɔ:n hʌsk] – šúpolie
cuisine [kwɪˈzi:n] – národná kuchyňa, jedlá
despite the fact – napriek skutočnosti
Easter – Veľká noc
embroidered – vyšívany
entry restriction [entri rɪˈstrɪkʃn] – obmedzenie vstupu
fairy tale castle – rozprávkový hrad
to fund – financovať
glacial [gleɪʃl] – ľadovcový
gnocchi [nɒki] – halušky
hatchet [hætʃɪt] – sekerka
historic (event, building, monument, centre) – historický (významný, slávny, známy v histórii)
historical (film, novel, development) – historický (faktický, zdokumentovaný, existujúci v minulosti)
to impose – zaviest'
jar [dʒa:(r)] – džbán
juniper gin [dʒu:nɪpə(r)] – borovička
laced [leɪsd] – čipkovaný
massif – masív
medieval [mediˈi:vəl] – stredoveký
membership – členstvo
natural beauty – prírodná krása
official – úradný
to participate in – zúčastniť sa na

peak [pi:k] – štít
picturesque [pɪktʃəˈresk] – malebný
pitcher [pɪtʃə(r)] – džbán
protected region – chránené územie
proud (of) – pyšný (na)
recent – nedávny
researcher – výskumník
rich (in) – bohatý (na)
roaring waterfall – hučiaci vodopád
settlement – osídlenie
Slovak National Uprising [ˌslɒvəˈkiːn ʌˈpraɪzɪŋ] – Slovenské národné povstanie
Slovak Paradise – Slovenský raj
spa resort – kúpeľné stredisko
spectacular scenery [ˌsɪːnəri] – pôsobivá scenéria
sphere [sfɪə(r)] – sféra, oblasť
surrounding – okolitý
tablecloth – obrus
the Carpathians – Karpaty
the High Tatras – Vysoké Tatry
throughout [θruːˈaʊt] – cez, počas
trade – obchod
valley – údolie
vast plain [ˈvɑːst pleɪn] – nekonečná, rozsiahla rovina
Velvet Revolution – Zamatová revolúcia
view – výhľad
World Heritage Cultural List – svetový zoznam kultúrneho dedičstva
at a height of – vo výške
to owe its popularity – vďačiť za svoju popularitu
visible from far and wide – viditeľný zo širokej dľaleka

VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 Odd one out. Circle the word which does not fit the others in each group.



<i>Example:</i>	territory	land	area	script
1.	inhabitant	prince	emperor	president
2.	cathedral	monument	monastery	church
3.	breweries	ironworks	fields	distilleries
4.	lakes	scenery	rivers	springs
5.	agriculture	economy	factory	industry
6.	gothic	baroque	rococo	medieval
7.	museum	gallery	tomb	exhibition
8.	seal	elections	flag	anthem
9.	established	founded	formed	disintegrated
10.	population	town	village	metropolis
11.	castles	spa resorts	caves	beer
12.	mountain	tradition	peak	hill
13.	spectacular	picturesque	fascinating	sightseeing
14.	songs	dances	costumes	patriots

Task 2 Read the following passage and fill in the missing articles A, AN, THE, or nothing (-).



The Slovak Republic is ¹ _____ independent state situated in ² _____ Central Europe. It is bordered to the west by ³ _____ Czech Republic, to the north by Poland, to the east by ⁴ _____ Ukraine, and to the south by Hungary and Austria. ⁵ _____ borders are mostly natural, made by ⁶ _____ rivers and mountains. ⁷ _____ most important rivers of ⁸ _____ Slovakia include ⁹ _____ Danube and ¹⁰ _____ Váh. In the course of ¹¹ _____ 20th century, many dams were built to serve ¹² _____ needs of hydro-electric power, the supply of water, agriculture, tourism and sports. There are ¹³ _____ beautiful mountain